

The City That Welcomes the Killer: How the Death of the High Priest Set You Free

Key Verse: Joshua 20:2–3 (KJV) – "Speak to the children of Israel, saying, Appoint out for you cities of refuge, whereof I spake unto you by the hand of Moses: That the slayer that killeth any person unawares and unwittingly may flee thither: and they shall be your refuge from the avenger of blood."

There is a chase that haunts every human soul. It is the pursuit of the avenger—the relentless, bloodthirsty hunter who does not sleep, does not tire, and does not negotiate. His name is Justice. **His name is the Law. His name is Death. And he is pursuing you because your hands are stained. You may not have intended the crime. You may have stumbled, slipped, or acted in ignorance. But the blood is on you nonetheless, and the avenger of blood is closing the gap.** His footsteps are at your back. His breath is on your neck. And you have nowhere to hide. But God, in His staggering mercy, did not leave you without a city. He did not abandon the guilty to the wrath of the righteous. He looked at the fugitive, the accidental murderer, the one who did not mean to sin but did—and He carved out sanctuaries in the wilderness. He built walls of refuge. He paved roads of escape. And He threw open gates of hope.

We come today to one of the most overlooked institutions in Scripture: the cities of refuge. These were six cities—three on the west of the Jordan and three on the east—appointed by God for the manslayer, the one who killed a person accidentally, without malice, without premeditation. He could flee to one of these cities, stand at the gate, present his case to the elders, and find safety from the avenger of blood. He was not set free immediately. **He had to remain inside the city until the death of the high priest. And when the high priest died, he was released to return to his own land, his own inheritance, his own people—and the avenger could never touch him again.** This is not a dusty legal relic from the wilderness. This is the Gospel in its raw, ancient, prophetic architecture. It is the blueprint of salvation. And it is time we preached the city of refuge with the urgency of a man who is still running.

Let us trace the horror of the fugitive's condition. The Law in Numbers 35 made it clear: "The revenger of blood himself shall slay the slayer: when he meeteth him, he shall slay him." (Numbers 35:19, KJV). No trial, no appeal, no mercy. The avenger was the nearest kinsman of the dead, and his duty was to exact blood for blood. This was the *lex talionis*—the

law of retaliation—and it was sacred. The slain demanded justice. The earth cried out for blood. And the manslayer, even though his act was unintentional, carried the stain of death. He was guilty, not of malice, but of causing the loss of life. And guilt demands punishment.

Now picture the fugitive. He is running. He cannot go home. His family cannot protect him. His friends cannot hide him. The avenger has the right. The avenger has the weapon. The avenger has the speed. The fugitive's only hope is to outrun the avenger to the gates of the city of refuge. **But here is the beauty of God's provision: the roads were to be maintained. Deuteronomy 19:3 (KJV) commands: "Thou shalt prepare thee a way, and divide the coasts of thy land, which the LORD thy God giveth thee to inherit, into three parts, that every slayer may flee thither."** The rabbis taught that the roads to the cities of refuge were kept in perfect repair—broad, smooth, and free of obstacles. At every crossroads, there were signs that said "Refuge! Refuge!" so that the fugitive would never lose his way. Do you see, beloved? God does not make salvation difficult to find. He does not hide the path. He does not plant thorns on the road. He clears the way. He puts up signs. He makes the gates of the city visible from a distance. The gospel is not a secret; it is a highway. "And an highway shall be there, and a way, and it shall be called The way of holiness." (Isaiah 35:8, KJV). The city of refuge is Christ, and the road to Him is wide open, well-marked, and ready for any runner.

But there is a condition. The fugitive does not simply run into the city and then leave when the heat dies down. He must stay inside. He must remain within the walls of the city until the death of the high priest. If he steps outside the city's boundary, the avenger has the right to kill him. Numbers 35:26–27 (KJV) declares: "But if the slayer shall at any time come without the border of the city of his refuge, whither he was fled; And the revenger of blood find him without the borders of the city of his refuge, and the revenger of blood kill the slayer; he shall not be guilty of blood." The walls of the city were not just a shelter; they were a limitation. **The fugitive was safe, but he was also confined. He could not go back to his old life. He could not return to his inheritance. He could not resume his former existence. He was a resident alien, a permanent refugee, until the high priest died. And only then could he go home.**

Now let the typology explode in your heart. The fugitive is you. The avenger of blood is the Law. The Law pursues you because you have broken it. You may not have murdered intentionally, but you have sinned. You may not have shed blood with malice, but you have broken the commandments. And the Law, that holy and just avenger,

demands your death. "For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God." (Romans 3:23, KJV). And "the wages of sin is death." (Romans 6:23, KJV). The avenger is at your heels. He is gaining. He has the right. He has the weapon. He will not relent. And where do you flee? You flee to Christ. He is the city of refuge. He is the wall of salvation. His gates are open to all—not just to the innocent, not just to the righteous, but to the guilty, the accidental, the stumbling, the one who did not mean to sin but did. The city was not for the righteous; it was for the guilty. The city was not for those who were without blood on their hands; it was for those who were stained. And Christ says, "Him that cometh to me I will in no wise cast out." (John 6:37, KJV). He does not ask if you meant it. He does not ask if you could have avoided it. He does not interrogate your motive. He throws open the gate and says, "Run here. Hide here. Live here."

But here is the deeper truth that few preach: the city of refuge is not just a place of safety; it is a place of confinement. When you come to Christ, you do not come as a visitor. You come as a resident. You cannot leave the city. You cannot go back to your old inheritance. You cannot return to your former life. You must stay in Him. "If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new." (2 Corinthians 5:17, KJV). You are no longer a free agent. You are a fugitive who has found shelter, and you must remain in the shelter. The world, the flesh, and the devil are the avengers, and if you step outside the walls of Christ, they will devour you. The walls are not a prison; they are your protection. The confinement is not a loss; it is your life.

Now let us weave this thread through the tapestry of Scripture. The cities of refuge are not an isolated curiosity; they are a prophetic constellation pointing to the High Priest who would die and set the captives free. In Numbers 35:25 (KJV), the text says: "He shall abide in it unto the death of the high priest, which was anointed with the holy oil." The fugitive was bound to the city until the high priest died. And when the high priest died—when he breathed his last—the chains were loosed. The fugitive could walk out of the city, return to his inheritance, and live in peace. The avenger could not touch him. The blood debt was not paid by the fugitive; it was paid by the high priest's death. The high priest's death was the substitutionary event that released the guilty. He did not kill the fugitive; he killed himself. He died so that the manslayer could live.

And who is our High Priest? It is Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the Great High Priest who entered into the holy place not with the blood of goats and calves, but with His own blood. Hebrews 9:11–12 (KJV) declares: "But Christ being come an high priest of good things to come... by his own blood he entered in once into the holy place, having obtained eternal redemption for us." And then Hebrews 9:15 (KJV) adds: "And for this cause he is the mediator of the new testament, that by means of death, for the redemption of the transgressions that were under the first testament, they which are called might receive the promise of eternal inheritance."

Do you see it? The high priest's death in the old covenant released the fugitive from the city of refuge. But in the new covenant, the High Priest—Jesus—died once, and His death did not merely release one fugitive; it released every fugitive who has ever fled to Him. His death was the cosmic death that ended the pursuit of the Law forever. When He cried, "It is finished!" (John 19:30, KJV), He was not just dying; He was discharging every fugitive from every city of refuge that ever existed. The avenger—the Law—lost his prey. The wrath of God was exhausted. The debt was paid. And the gates of the city were thrown open—not for us to leave the city, but for us to realize that the city is now the whole world. The High Priest has died, and now there is no condemnation. "There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus." (Romans 8:1, KJV).

Let us bring the crescendo to its peak. The cities of refuge were six in number—three on each side of the Jordan. They were strategically placed so that no fugitive was more than a half-day's journey from one. They were named: Kedesh, Shechem, and Hebron on the west; Bezer, Ramoth, and Golan on the east. But the Psalmist says in Psalm 46:1 (KJV): "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble." He does not name the city; He names the God of the city. **The city is not a place; it is a Person. And He is not far from you. He is not across the Jordan. He is not on the other side of the desert. He is as near as your breath and as close as your cry. The road is clear. The signs are posted. The gate is open. And the High Priest has already died.**

Now, what is your response? Are you still running? Are you still trying to outrun the avenger on your own strength? Stop running. Stop hiding in the bushes. Stop covering your shame with fig leaves. The city is before you. The walls are high. The gates are wide. The road is smooth. And the High Priest is dead—not to doom you, but to release you. Run to Christ. Enter the city. Stay in the city. And when the avenger comes to the gate, he will see the blood of the High Priest on the lintel and the doorposts, and he will pass over you. He will not

enter. He cannot enter. The blood has satisfied him. The death has settled the debt. The avenger is defeated.

And here is the final, glorious mystery: the High Priest who died is not dead anymore. He is risen. He ascended to the right hand of the Father. And now He is not only your refuge; He is your eternal High Priest who lives forever to make intercession for you. Hebrews 7:25 (KJV): "Wherefore he is able also to save them to the uttermost that come unto God by him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession for them." You are not just released; you are seated with Him in heavenly places. The city is not just a hiding place; it is a throne room. So, beloved fugitive, lay down your guilt. Lay down your fear. Lay down your running. You have reached the city. The avenger is gone. The debt is paid. The High Priest has died—and He lives again. And now you may go home. Not to the old inheritance, but to a new one—an inheritance incorruptible, undefiled, and that fadeth not away, reserved in heaven for you. (1 Peter 1:4, KJV).

"The name of the LORD is a strong tower: the righteous runneth into it, and is safe." (Proverbs 18:10, KJV). Run, beloved. Run into the tower. The gates are open, and the High Priest has already died. You are forever free.